THE GREYHOUNDS WERE TRAINED FOR A WAR THAT NO LONGER LOOKS THE SAME. For more than three decades, the elite police force of undivided Andhra Pradesh and, later, Telangana as well, hunted Maoist guerrillas through some of central India's most difficult terrain. Created in the late 1980s as Left-wing extremism (LWE) intensified, the Greyhounds became one of the country's most closely watched counter-insurgency units, earning a reputation for jungle warfare, intelligence-led operations and tactical precision.

That history is now colliding with a new reality. With Union home minister Amit Shah declaring India Naxal-free earlier this year, and the police leadership of Telangana and Andhra Pradesh declaring the armed Maoist presence in their states effectively over, the two governments are confronting a very different question: what should become of a force created for an insurgency that has receded?



Even before the Centre's March 31 deadline for eliminating Maoism, Telangana chief minister Revanth Reddy had advocated scaling down the Greyhounds, suggesting that its personnel be redeployed to other police wings. "When the purpose is achieved, what is the use of continuing well-trained personnel there?" he said at the Telangana Police Officers' Retreat 2026 on March 9, two days after as many as 130 Maoists surrendered in his presence in Hyderabad.

The Telangana police department moved quickly. Around half of its roughly 1,250 Greyhounds personnel are being redeployed across eight police wings, alongside personnel from the Special Intelligence Branch (SIB) and some from OCTOPUS, the Organisation for Counter Terrorist Operations. Andhra Pradesh, by contrast, is proceeding more cautiously, wary of downsizing a force whose history also offers a warning about how quickly an apparently defeated insurgency can regroup.

A FORCE APART

The Greyhounds took shape in the late 1980s, when united Andhra Pradesh was confronting escalating LWE and related violence. It evolved into its present form by 1989 under Indian Police Service (IPS) officer K.S. Vyas during the tenure of chief minister N.T. Rama Rao. Vyas was shot dead by the People's War Group in Hyderabad in January 1993. The losses continued. Over 60 Greyhounds personnel have been killed in the line of duty. The deadliest episode came on June 29, 2008, when 32 commandos and six other personnel were killed in a Maoist ambush, while travelling by boats across the Balimela reservoir on the Andhra Pradesh-Odisha border.

Yet Greyhounds operations, intelligence-gathering by the SIB and effective policing went hand-in-hand with government welfare and development programmes. This helped to bring insurgent activity in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana down substantially by 2017, even as the Maoists retained greater influence in neighbouring parts of central India, particularly Chhattisgarh.

Though anti-insurgent units in other states, such as Chhattisgarh's District Reserve Guards, Maharashtra's C-60, Odisha's Special Operations Group and the CRPF's CoBRA, were inspired by or modelled on its methods, few have matched the Greyhounds' results. "While Greyhounds are the perfectly trained assault commandos, the unit's unparalleled successes can be attributed to the exceptional guidance and support from their anti-Maoist intelligence unit, SIB. Together they achieved a synchrony and precision comparable with that of Israel's Mossad," says Kalyan Elesela, DIG, Chhattisgarh police, who has served in the Maoist-affected Bastar region.

95
of 425 OCTOPUS (or Organisation for Counter Terrorist Operations) commandos in active duty being reassigned

ANDHRA PRADESH
Holding the Line
No immediate downsizing planned

1,200
Greyhounds commandos in active duty

300
Special Intelligence Branch personnel

480
OCTOPUS commandos in the police force